

Quality of Life Measurement in Vitiligo: Position Statement of the European Academy of Dermatology and Venereology Task Force on Quality of Life and Patient Oriented Outcomes with External Experts

Abstract

Members of the European Academy of Dermatology and Venereology (EADV) Task Force on Quality of Life (QoL) and Patient Oriented Outcomes, together with external vitiligo experts—including representatives from the EADV Vitiligo Task Force—reviewed available health-related quality of life (HRQoL) instruments for vitiligo and provided practical recommendations for assessing QoL in patients with vitiligo.

The **Dermatology Life Quality Index (DLQI)** was the most commonly used HRQoL instrument in vitiligo studies, enabling cross-country comparison of results. Several vitiligo-specific tools have been developed, among which the **Vitiligo Impact Scale (VIS)** stands out as an extensively validated instrument. The VIS-22 version includes established minimal important change values and clinical interpretation guidelines. However, it was developed in India, where specific cultural beliefs about vitiligo may influence responses.

The EADV Task Force recommends using the **DLQI** for adults and the **Children's Dermatology Life Quality Index (CDLQI)** for pediatric

patients as standard dermatology-specific instruments in vitiligo. There remains a critical need for a globally valid, cross-culturally adapted vitiligo-specific HRQoL instrument—either newly developed or improved from existing tools—with demonstrated responsiveness to change.

Introduction

Vitiligo is the most common depigmenting skin disorder, affecting approximately **0.5% to 2%** of the global population across all age groups. It affects males and females equally, though women and girls tend to seek medical consultation more frequently. Management of vitiligo remains a significant challenge in dermatology.

Beyond its physical manifestations, vitiligo can lead to **severe psychological distress**, reduced quality of life (QoL), and increased risk of psychiatric comorbidities such as anxiety and depression. Patients with darker skin types often report greater HRQoL impairment due to more visible contrast in depigmentation. Cultural, social, and religious factors further shape perceptions of the condition, influencing stigma and coping mechanisms.

Psychoeducational interventions focusing on **acceptance and social adjustment** are often necessary. To accurately assess the burden of vitiligo, several disease-specific HRQoL instruments have been developed worldwide.

The EADV Task Force on QoL and Patient Oriented Outcomes has previously published guidance on selecting and using HRQoL instruments in dermatological conditions. Building on this work, the Task Force—alongside external vitiligo experts—conducted a review of HRQoL assessment tools specifically for vitiligo to provide evidence-based recommendations.

Methods

The review involved members of the EADV Task Force on QoL and Patient Oriented Outcomes and external experts, including representatives from the EADV Vitiligo Task Force.

A literature search was conducted in **PubMed (1990–October 2021)** using the keyword combination: "*quality of life, vitiligo*". This effort supported the development of a Position Statement and was not intended as a systematic review.

All volunteers were assigned sections of the identified publications for evaluation.

Inclusion Criteria

- Publications written in English or with an English abstract

Exclusion Criteria

- Review articles, guidelines, and study protocols
- Studies without HRQoL assessment
- HRQoL assessments in conditions other than vitiligo
- Studies assessing HRQoL in multiple diseases without separate reporting or discussion of vitiligo data

Two co-authors independently assessed all publications. Discrepancies were discussed and resolved through consensus. The remaining studies were analyzed in detail to identify and evaluate HRQoL instruments used in vitiligo.

The Task Force endorses the use of the term "**quimp**" (quality of life impairment) in both clinical practice and research, and this terminology has been applied throughout the document.